ELIMINATION PLAYS

ABOUT THE DEALS

Feel free to disagree with the bidding; remember that it is only there so as to get to a contract appropriate for some particular elimination play. In fact, the bidding is irrelevant except in Deals where the opponent's bids may influence your actions.

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. This is to get you started thinking about how you would play the hand.

There are four or five stages shown for each Deal.

You are always going to be the Declarer, playing in the South position.

ELIMINATION PLAYS SUMMARY

There are a lot of card combinations in Bridge in which you will be better off if the opponents make the first play in a suit than you would be if you must play it first. Here are three examples.

♦ K 10 3	♦ J 7 3	♦ K 10 3
♦ A J 7	♦ Q 5 2	♦ A 9 7

The first is the frequently occurring two-way finesse. If you play this yourself you have to guess which defender holds the Queen. If the defenders start the suit you automatically win all three tricks.

In the second example you'd like to win one trick, and it will be hard to do if you must start the suit. Perhaps one defender holds both the high honors and you can guess which one and lead through him. Or perhaps someone has a doubleton honor that you can deduce. But if the defenders break the suit you just play second-hand-low and can't miss winning one trick.

With the third example you have almost no chance of three tricks if you start. If they start the suit you play second-hand-low and the next defender must play an honor. You win and then finesse the other defender for the other honor, winning all three tricks when their two honors are divided.

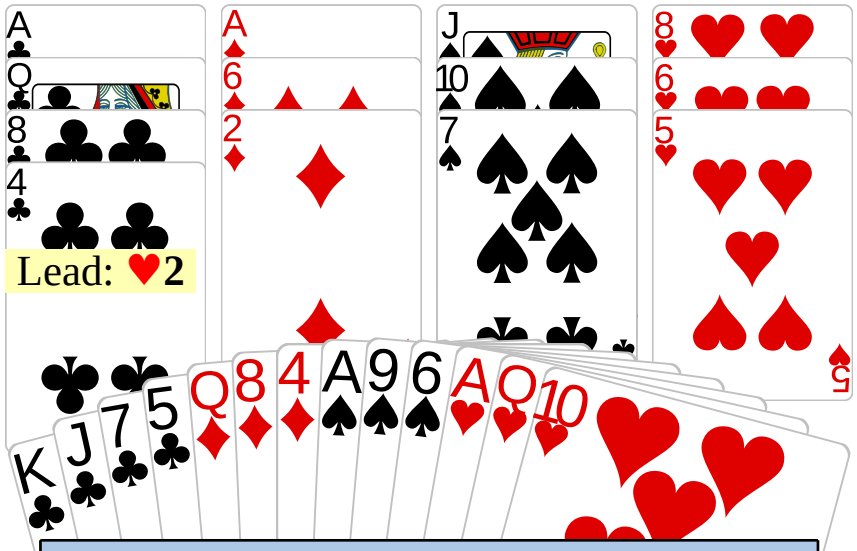
These are only three of many combinations that will benefit you if you can force the defenders to start the suit.
And that is what Elimination plays do; force the defenders to play a particular suit for you.

It works like this. You **strip** the defenders of all their "safe" exit suits, then you **throw-in** one of the defenders. If he has no safe exit, he will have to play a suit that will benefit you, perhaps one of the combinations above.

You will find that most elimination plays occur in suit contracts. This is because you can often pull all the defender's trumps while retaining at least one in both your hand and dummy. Then when the throw-in occurs the defense cannot play a suit of which you and dummy are both void because of the threat of a ruff and sluff.

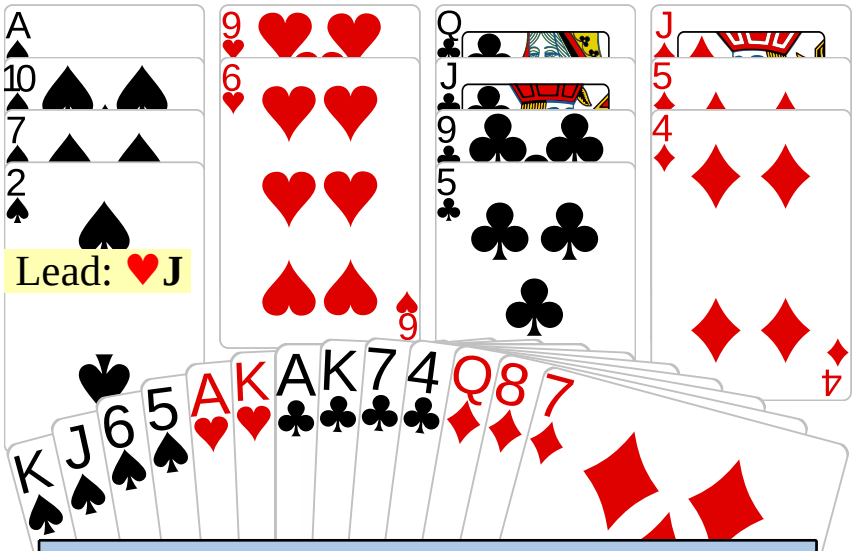
25 examples are probably worth more than 1000 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: **3NT** Goal: at least _____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 2 Ctr: **4♠** Goal: at most _____ losers



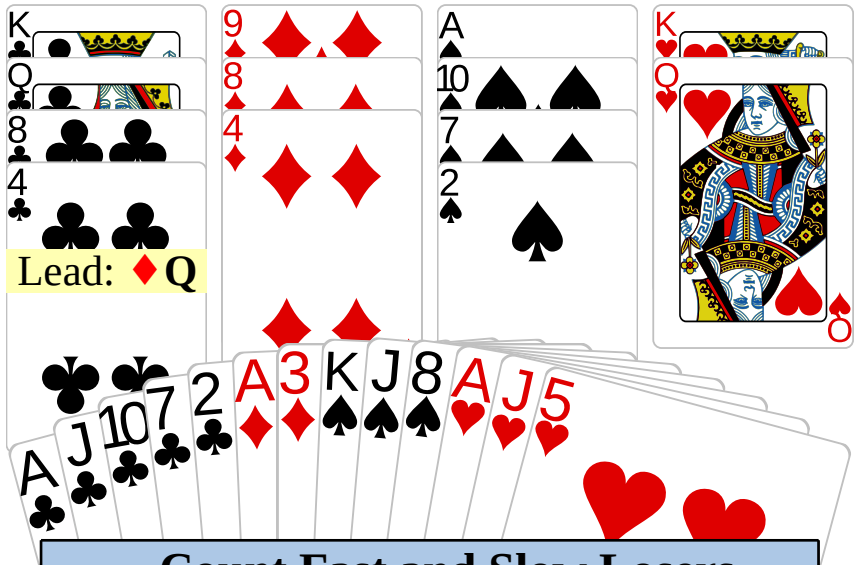
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 3 Ctr: **6♣** Goal: at most ____ losers



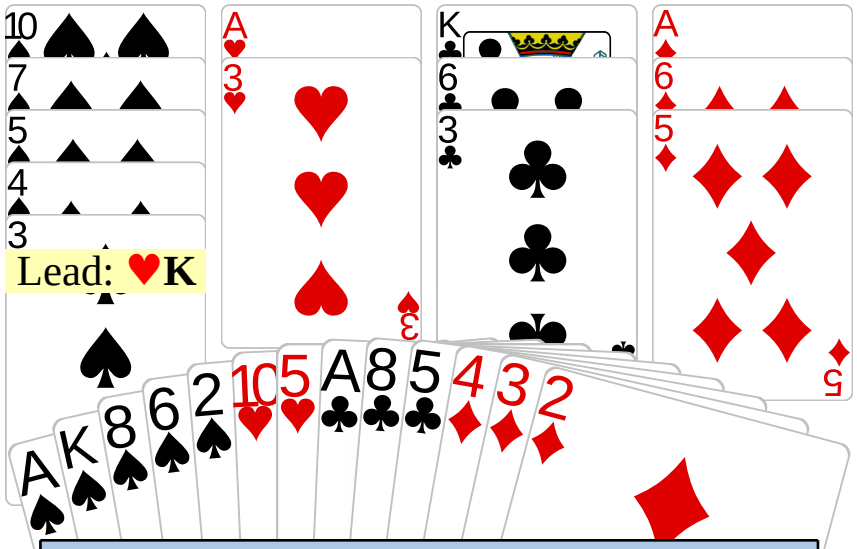
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 4 Ctr: **6♣** Goal: at most ____ losers



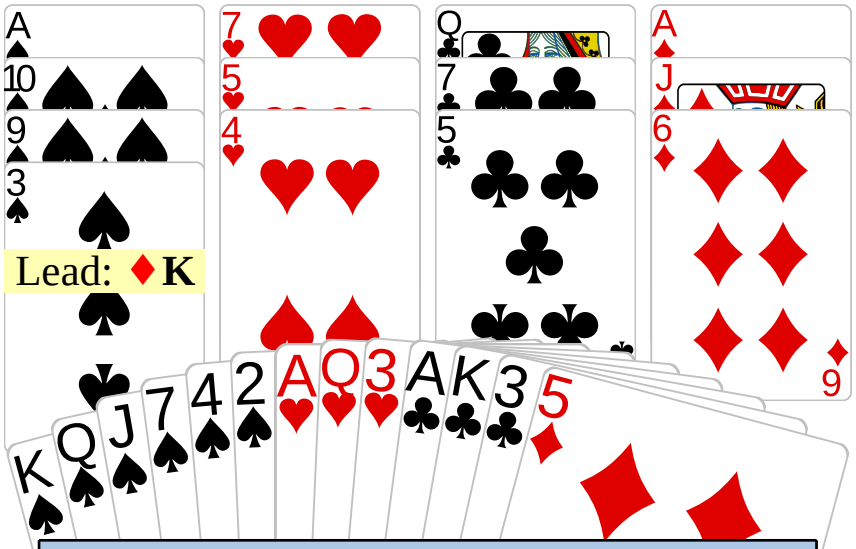
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 5 Ctr: **4♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 6 Ctr: **6♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥2

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥J

Board: 3
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6♣
Declarer: South
Lead: ♠J

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 6♣
Declarer: West
Lead: ♦Q

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥K

Board: 6
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦K

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A 9 6 ♥ A Q 10 ♦ Q 8 4 ♣ K J 7 5	
♠ 8 5 4 3 ♥ J 4 3 ♦ J 10 9 ♣ 9 6 2		♠ K Q 2 ♥ K 9 7 2 ♦ K 7 5 3 ♣ 10 3
	♠ J 10 7 ♥ 8 6 5 ♦ A 6 2 ♣ A Q 8 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥2

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥2. West plays the ♥J which you win with the ♥Q.

You have one trick already in the bag, four more to come in ♣s, and three other Aces. So all you have to do it get one of those finesse positions to come through. By now, though, you must have figured that nothing is going to work! Even your best shot, West holding at least one of ♠ K Q will not happen. The answer (again) is to eliminate, then throw in.

This time there is only one suit you can eliminate, ♣s. So play all four ♣s, ending in dummy. They split 3-2.

West plays low.

You play the ♠J from dummy and let it ride when West follows with a low card. (If West had covered you would win the Ace then set up a second trick in the suit.)East wins with the ♠Q, and guess what?

HE IS ENDPLAYED!. He has no ♣s, and whichever other suit he plays will give you your ninth trick!

Wow! End-played at trick #6.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 9 4 ♥ Q 7 5 3 2 ♦ A 9 3 ♣ 8 6 3	
♠ A 10 7 2 ♥ 9 6 ♦ J 5 4 ♣ Q J 9 5	N W E S	♠ K J 6 5 ♥ A K ♦ Q 8 7 ♣ A K 7 4
	♠ Q 8 3 ♥ J 10 8 4 ♦ K 10 6 2 ♣ 10 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2NT	Pass
3♣	Pass	3♠	Pass
4♠			
All Pass			

4♠ by East
Lead: ♥J

East is to play 4♠ after West's Stayman bid uncovered the 4-4 fit. South leads the ♥J which you win the your ♥A.

With three possible losers in ♦s you might first think that you will have to finesse one of the defenders for the trump Queen. But anytime you see an unsupported Jack opposite an unsupported Queen you should start thinking about a throw-in play. And what better card to use for the throw-in than the Queen of trumps.

So pull two rounds of trumps with the ♠A and ♠K, hoping the ♠Q falls. She doesn't fall, but both defenders do follow suit. So the ♠Q is the only trump outstanding.

Next eliminate ♥s from you and dummy by playing the ♥K.

Now play four rounds of ♣s to eliminate that suit. If a defender decides to ruff one of these ♣s with the master trump he will be end-played, forced to either play a ♦ or to give you a ruff-sluff. So assume that all four ♣s win tricks.

Now you administer the coup de grace.

You lead a trump.

One of the defenders has won the ♠Q. Too bad for him. If he now plays a ♦ you will make either the ♦Q or ♦J. If he plays a ♥ you will ruff in one hand and discard a ♦ loser from the other.

It is clear that the elimination play saved you having to guess the finesse for the ♠Q.

But what if you considered yourself a really good guesser? So good that you felt confident in taking the finesse, and so good that you pulled it off successfully.

You'd be no better off. Although you would avoid the ♠ loser you would now have to play the ♦s for yourself and you would lose three ♦s!

Board 3
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ Q 5 ♥ A J 6 2 ♦ A 9 6 4 ♣ A J 5	
♠ J 10 9 7 2 ♥ K 10 7 4 ♦ Q 8 2 ♣ 7	N W E S	♠ K 8 6 3 ♥ Q 9 8 3 ♦ 10 7 5 ♣ 8 2
	♠ A 4 ♥ 5 ♦ K J 3 ♣ K Q 10 9 6 4 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	3♣
Pass	4♣	Pass	6♣
All Pass			

6♣ by South
Lead: ♠J

South considered Blackwood, then realized if North showed either 2 or 3 Aces he was going to bid slam. But if North showed just one Ace he would have to maneuver to play 5NT which might be worse than 6♣. So he just bid the slam. South plays 6♣. West leads the ♠J.

You wish, you hope, you may even pray, but when you play the ♠Q East covers with the ♠K. So you know you have a ♠ loser. And unless East holds the ♦Q you might have a ♦ loser also.

Perhaps an elimination play will improve your chances. Don't lead a trump yet though, you're going to need several entries to dummy to eliminate the ♥s.

Win the ♠, play to the ♥A and ruff a ♥.

Play a trump to dummy's ♣J (both defenders follow)

and ruff another ♥ high.

Play to dummy's ♣A, pulling their last trump, and ruff the last ♥.

You execute the throw-in by leading a ♠. If West wins the trick he will have to play ♦s for you or give you a ruff-sluff. So if these are competent defenders they will make sure that it is **EAST** who wins the ♠ trick. So he does, and he plays a small ♦.

East leads a small ♦.

DO NOT PLAY THE JACK! If the finesse is going to work now it will still work one trick later. By playing low you take advantage of the possibility that East held the ♦10 and West will have to put on the ♦Q to prevent you taking a trick with dummy's ♦9.

Many elimination endings give you a sure thing. Others just improve your chances.

Here you had two chances. First, West might have HAD to win the throw-in, either because he had all of the high ♠s, or more likely because he messed up. The second chance paid off when East took the throw-in but you found a fortunate position with the ♦s.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 9 6 5 ♥ 9 8 4 3 ♦ K Q 10 5 2 ♣ 6	
♠ K J 8 ♥ A J 5 ♦ A 3 ♣ A J 10 7 2	N W E S	♠ A 10 7 2 ♥ K Q ♦ 9 8 4 ♣ K Q 8 4
	♠ Q 4 3 ♥ 10 7 6 2 ♦ J 7 6 ♣ 9 5 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♣	Pass	1♠	Pass
2NT	Pass	4♣	Pass
6♣			
All Pass			

6♣ by West
Lead: ♦Q

a ♠ loser from your hand.

The slam was easy to bid, now you just have to make it. West plays 6♣. North leads the ♦Q.

You have one certain ♦ loser, and a two-way finesse for the ♠Q. That should make you start thinking about elimination and throw-in. So win the ♦A and pull trumps, North having a singleton.

You eliminate the ♥s: the ♥K, the ♥Q overtaken by your ♥A, then the ♥J.

BE CAREFUL! On the ♥J you must discard a ♦ from dummy so both of you will be out of ♦s at the throw-in.

NOW you can execute the throw-in. Play your ♦, which eliminates ♦s from both you and dummy and at the same time throws in one of the defenders. Whoever it is will be forced to lead a ♠ and eliminate your guess for the ♠Q or else give you a ruff-sluff, allowing you to ruff in dummy and discard

Among Bridge players you often hear about someone (usually Aunt Harriet) who is amazingly lucky at guessing the location of missing Queens.

Perhaps Aunt Harriet isn't that lucky after all, perhaps she just knows how to perform elimination plays.

Hopefully in the future you will be the one with the reputation!

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A K 8 6 2 ♥ 10 5 ♦ 4 3 2 ♣ A 8 5	
♠ — ♥ 9 6 ♦ K Q J 10 8 7 ♣ Q J 9 7 2	N W E S	♠ Q J 9 ♥ K Q J 8 7 4 2 ♦ 9 ♣ 10 4
	♠ 10 7 5 4 3 ♥ A 3 ♦ A 6 5 ♣ K 6 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♠	4♥	4♠
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♥K

When the bidding gets high in a hurry you sometimes have to guess what you can make. North plays 4♠. East leads the ♥K.

And it looks like you are too high. Assuming the trumps split 2-1, you still have one ♥ loser, two ♦ losers and one ♣ loser.

You win the ♥A and play a ♠ to your ♠K. West discards a ♦!

From bad to worse. Now you must add a ♠ loser to the four you already had. Are you finished?

No, never give up. East has a bunch of ♥s and 3 ♠s, so he cannot have many ♦s and ♣s. If you can eliminate those and then throw him in it should work to your advantage.

Play your ♠A, the ♦A and the ♣ A K. East follows to everything.

You've done all you can do. Now play the ♥10 to East's high ♥.

East has just won his side's first trick with the ♥J. He now plays the ♠Q, winning his side's second trick.

Now, East is still on lead, and he has nothing in his hand but good ♥s.

So he leads the ♥Q.

You **DO NOT RUFF**. Instead you discard a ♣ from dummy and a ♦ from your hand. East has now taken his side's third trick. He plays another good ♥, and you ruff in dummy and discard the last ♦ loser from your hand. You can now cross-ruff for the rest of the tricks.

Incredible isn't it.

You just wonder how many bridge players would have just conceded down 2 on this hand.

Not you or me, of course.

Board 6
North Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ 8 5 ♥ J 10 9 6 ♦ 9 8 7 4 ♣ J 9 2	
♠ A 10 9 3 ♥ 7 5 4 ♦ A J 6 ♣ Q 7 5	N W E S	♠ K Q J 7 4 2 ♥ A Q 3 ♦ 5 ♣ A K 3
	♠ 6 ♥ K 8 2 ♦ K Q 10 3 2 ♣ 10 8 6 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	Pass	1♠	Pass
3♠	Pass	4NT[1]	Pass
5♥[2]	Pass	6♠	
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♠ by East
Lead: ♦K

West's 3♠ is a limit raise, 11-12 points in support of ♠s. When you discover that the raise includes two Aces you bid the slam. East plays 6♠. South leads the ♦K, won by you with dummy's ♦A.

Is this a really easy elimination play showing up this late in the group? Or are you just getting better at seeing them? In any case, you should see that a successful ♥ finesse will land your contract, but you should also remember that there aren't many finesses working on these 25 deals.

So rather than finesse, eliminate! Pull trumps in two rounds, ending in dummy.

Ruff the ♦6, then play ♣A, ♣K, ♣Q.

So here you are in dummy. Do you finesse the ♥ now?

North plays low.

Of course not. You play the ♦J and discard a small ♥ from your hand. South wins his ♦Q (which his opening lead told you he held) and is end-played. He must lead a ♥ to your tenace or give you a ruff-sluff.

The answer to the question posed above is:

It is a pretty simple problem, but you are no doubt getting a lot better.